

Prominence, Intervention, and Attraction in Georgian Agreement

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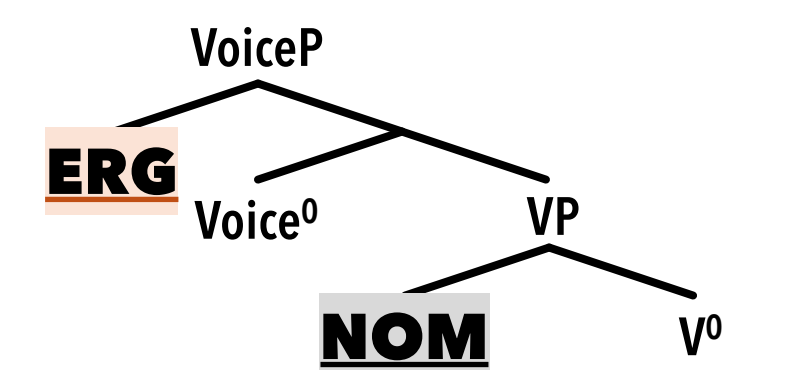


Georgian agreement shows hierarchy effects that diverge from binding. We analyze them as intervention effects fed by abstract movement. Such a grammar is especially likely given an acquisition strategy of correlating prominence with height, and perhaps likely to grammaticize from agreement attraction errors.

1. Binding across argument structures

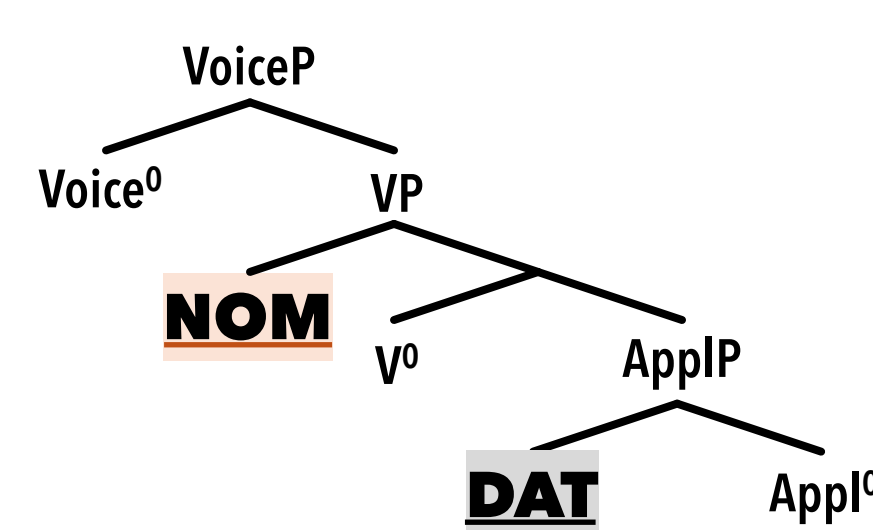
Across three morphosyntactically distinct clause types, Condition A diagnoses base c-command relations [1,2]

(1) Active transitive



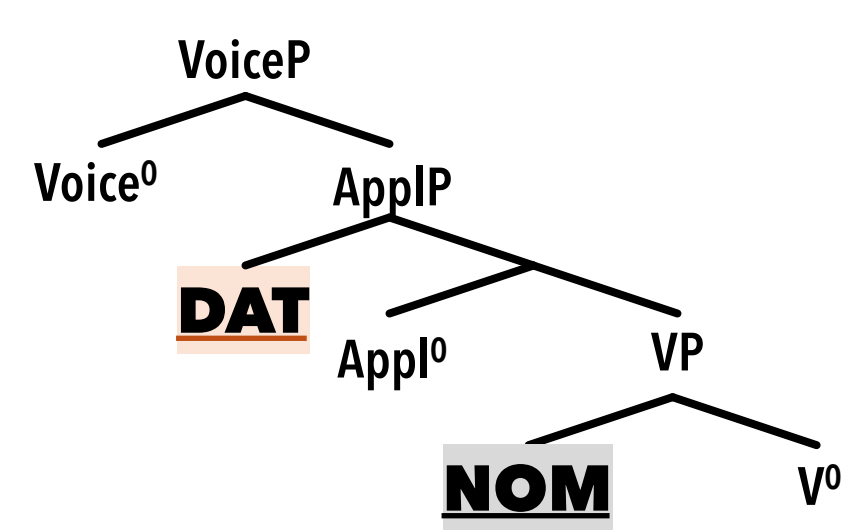
kʰirurg-ma tʰavisi tʰav-i ga-a-kʰritʰikʰ-a.
surgeon-ERG self's self-NOM PVB-INFL-criticize-AOR
"The surgeon criticized himself."

(2) Deponent transitive



kʰirurg-i tʰavis tʰav-s da-e-xmar-a.
surgeon-NOM self's self-DAT PVB-INFL-help-AOR
"The surgeon helped himself."

(3) Psych transitive

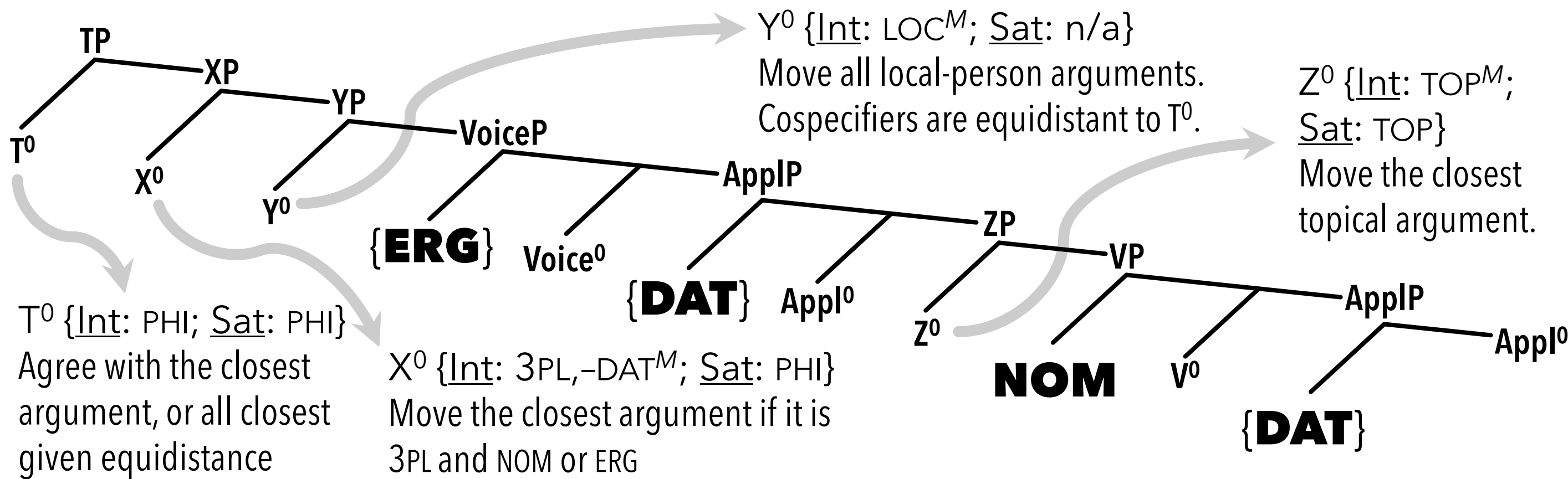


kʰirurg-s tʰavisi tʰav-i mo-e-tsʰon-a.
surgeon-DAT self's self-NOM PVB-INFL-like-AOR
"The surgeon liked himself."

Phrase-structural height correlates (imperfectly) with thematic prominence – as is typologically robust [3]

3. Translating a hierarchy into intervention effects

Certain arguments move to certain abstract positions, potentially feeding or bleeding agreement with T   [6]



- Topicalization feeds object agreement, but only given the lowest type of subject

(4) $[_{TP} T^0 [_{XP} X^0 [_{YP} Y^0 [_{V_{CP}} Vc^0 [_{ZP} \text{DAT}_{[3PL, TOP]} Z^0 [_{VP} \text{NOM}_{[3SG]} V^0 [_{ApP} t Ap^0] \dots}] \dots]]$
da-e-xmar-a-*th*

(5) $[_{TP} T^0 [_{XP} X^0 [_{YP} Y^0 [_{V_{CP}} Vc^0 [_{ApP} \text{DAT}_{[3SG]} Ap^0 [_{ZP} \text{NOM}_{[3PL, TOP]} Z^0 [_{VP} t V^0] \dots}] \dots]]$
mo-e-tsʰon-a

- 1st/2nd objects intervene on agreement with 3PL.DAT subjects

(6) $[_{TP} T^0 [_{XP} X^0 [_{YP} \text{NOM}_{[1SG]} Y^0 [_{V_{CP}} Vc^0 [_{ApP} \text{DAT}_{[3PL]} Ap^0 [_{ZP} Z^0 [_{VP} V^0 [_{VP} t V^0] \dots}] \dots]]$
mo-ve-tsʰon-*e*

- Only LOC>LOC verbs agree with both arguments

(7) $[_{TP} T^0 [_{XP} X^0 [_{YP} \text{DAT}_{[2PL]} \text{NOM}_{[1SG]} Y^0 [_{V_{CP}} Vc^0 [_{ApP} t Ap^0 [_{ZP} Z^0 [_{VP} V^0 [_{VP} t V^0] \dots}] \dots]]$
mo-ge-tsʰon-*e-th*

- 3PL.ERG/NOM subjects bleed agreement with local objects

(8) $[_{TP} T^0 [_{XP} \text{ERG}_{[3PL]} X^0 [_{YP} \text{NOM}_{[2PL]} Y^0 [_{V_{CP}} t Vc^0 [_{ZP} Z^0 [_{VP} t V^0] \dots}] \dots]]$
ga-ga-kʰritʰikʰ-*es*

2. Complex bleeding and feeding effects in suffixal agreement

Sensitive to various prominence scales: role, case, & topicality [4]

- Always agree with the subject and not the object...

	Active "ERG criticized NOM"	Deponent "NOM helped DAT"	Psych "DAT liked NOM"
3PL>3SG	ga-a-kʰritʰikʰ- <i>es</i>	da-e-xmar- <i>nen</i>	mo-e-tsʰon-a- <i>th</i>
3SG>3PL	ga-a-kʰritʰikʰ-a	da-e-xmar-a	moe-tsʰon-a

- ...Except that local-person arguments always control agreement...

3SG>2PL	ga-ga-kʰritʰikʰ-a- <i>th</i>	da-ge-xmar-a- <i>th</i>	2PL>3(PL)	mo-ge-tsʰon-a- <i>th</i>
1SG>3PL	ga-va-kʰritʰikʰ- <i>e</i>	da-ve-xmar- <i>e</i>	3SG>1SG	mo-ve-tsʰon- <i>e</i>
1SG>2PL	ga-ga-kʰritʰikʰ- <i>e-th</i>	da-ge-xmar- <i>e-th</i>	2PL>1SG	mo-ge-tsʰon- <i>e-th</i>

- ...Unless there's a 3PL ergative or nominative subject...

3PL>2PL	ga-ga-kʰritʰikʰ- <i>es</i>	da-ge-xmar- <i>nen</i>	3PL>2SG	mo-e-tsʰon- <i>e</i>
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- ...And, for some speakers, topical/pronominal objects of deponents can control exceptional 3PL suffixes: innovative topic agreement [5]

3SG>3PL.TOP	ga-a-kʰritʰikʰ-a	da-e-xmar-a- <i>%(th)</i>	3SG>3PL.TOP	mo-e-tsʰon-a
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Descriptively, a hierarchy:

$$3PL.S_{ERG, NOM} > 1ST/2ND > S_{ERG, DAT} > \%(O_{DAT, TOP}) > S_{NOM} > O$$

4. Theoretical takeaways

Operations' sensitivity to chain links / **levels of representation**

- Base position: Condition A
- Links in Spec-X/Y/ZP: Suffixal agr
- Scrambled links: Surface order

Probe decomposition instead of probe specification

- $[_{TP} T^0 [_{Int: F, Sat: F}] [_{XP} X^0 [_{Int: G^M, Sat: G}] \dots]]$
instead of $[_{V_{CP}} Voice^0 [_{Int: F, Sat: G}] \dots]$

Equidistance as a loophole for intervention constraints [7]

- Rather than cyclic probing

Testable **predictions**

- Mvmt of $S_{3PL, NOM}$ to Spec-XP should bleed agr w/ $O_{3PL, DAT, TOP}$
- Implicational hierarchy: topic agr for active O → for psych O → for deponent O (height of ZP)

5. Connections to processing

Why this grammar over others [8,9]? **Iconicity of prominence**

- An acquisition aid? More prominent means higher in the phrase structure

Processing **errors and change**

- Topic agr occurs where arguments are least distinct in prominence
- Indistinct → hard to co-manage in memory [10] → attraction errors more likely [11] → grammaticalization
- Part of a trend in Georgian of DAT gaining subjecthood properties [5]

Psycholinguistic directions

- Deponent verbs should be hardest to process and most error prone
- Relative prominence of objects should ameliorate judgements of ungrammatical object agreement
- Computational modeling of errors [12] and acquisition [13,14]

We gratefully acknowledge support of the Etoile Montante scheme from the Pays de la Loire region, France, under grant #2025_00211 (CrossPlur, PI: J  r  my Pasquereau) • **References:** [1] Harris, A. C. 1981. *Georgian Syntax*, Cambridge. [2] Nash, L. 2021. Nonunitary structure of unergative verbs in Georgian. *NLLT*. [3] Dowty, D. 1991. Thematic proto-roles and argument selection. *Lg*. [4] Foley, S. 2021. Agreement. In *Oxford Handbook of Lgs of the Caucasus*. [5] Tuite, K. 1998. Kartvelian morphosyntax. U of Montreal diss. [6] Deal, A. R. To appear. Current models of Agree. In *Move and Agree*. [7] Oxford, W. 2019. Inverse marking and Multiple Agree in Algonquian. *NLLT*. [8] Thivi  ge, S. 2021. Phasehood and phi-intervention. UMD diss. [9] Bondarenko, T. & Zoppi, S. 2025. Leftover agreement. *NLLT*. [10] Bornkessel-Schlesewsky, I. & Schlewsky, M. 2009. The role of prominence information in the real-time comprehension of transitive constructions. *Lg & Ling Compass*. [11] Wagers, M., et al. 2009. Agreement attraction in comprehension. *J of Mem & Lg*. [12] Engelmann, F., et al. 2019. The effect of prominence and cue association on retrieval processes. *Cog Sci*. [13] Yang, C. 2016. *The Price of Linguistic Productivity*. MIT. [14] Pearl, L. & Sprouse, J. 2021. The acquisition of linking theories. *Lg Acquisition*.

